Prepare choices, make clear rulings

Preparing and adjudicating / Use the shared rules in Play and Create.

Before the first scene

Agree setting, tone, boundaries, character level/BU, equipment and how advancement will be awarded. State how lethal stakes and table exceptions will be handled. Everyone should know what their current record actually grants. A Library build is a beginning, not a mandatory class.

Prepare a situation with **people who want things**, a visible problem, pressure if nothing changes and more than one useful approach. Give players information from which they can make decisions. Ordinary investigation, negotiation and tools remain available without buying a primitive for every act.

Small preparation record: place; immediate problem; participants/motives; observable facts; pressures; routes and obstacles; possible consequences; unresolved questions. Prepare consequences, not a compulsory solution.

The ruling sequence

1. Ask what result is intended. Distinguish the desired outcome from a named skill or power.
2. Establish ordinary support and actual extraordinary access. Read the bound Verb, Domain and other relevant rules.
3. Clarify located targets, reach, delivery, output, arrangement, timing and persistence. A short ordinary task may need only a sentence.
4. Identify the real uncertainty. Secure result: describe it. Uncertain task: check. Timing collision: Clash. Opposed effort: Contest. Attack or save: use the actual working.
5. Agree DC/approach where needed, success, failure, Cost and timing before commitment. Let the player accept, narrow or revise.
6. Resolve, apply the agreed changes and continue from them. Keep ongoing consequences visible.

There is no universal task-DC ladder, critical multiplier, surprise entitlement or Cost-to-Vitality tariff in these defaults. Judge the actual challenge and explain the stakes. A high roll does not grant missing permanent access.

Price the actual permission

Suggested acquisition anchors are in **Create**. Review behavior, subject, scale, recipients, conditions, duration and stacking. A label such as "guardian" supplies no armor; a family name supplies no unlisted behavior.

Accept a clear proposal, request a narrower/wider rule or revise its proposed price. Test an ordinary use, a stretched use and an outside-scope use. Existing acquisitions can be rearranged without being charged again; new actual acquisitions still need accounting.

Appraise pressure, not just numbers

Strain grades 0–6 run from effortless to catastrophic. Weigh scale, impact, dependencies, urgency, opposition, environment, tools and help. The same owned ingredients can support a small easy use or a demanding larger expression.

State the **actual Cost**: resource, Vitality, task, restriction, numerical change, loss of access, environmental effect or narrative obligation. Combinations and negligible Costs are possible. Cost is not acquisition BU repurchased each use.

If useful, compare evaluated minimum B with selected use A: increase = A − B; total CV = A. This optional arithmetic neither determines every consequence nor grants a new permission.

Run the shared rhythm

Council coordinates intentions and dependencies. Fast resolves Complexity 0–1; Measured 2–3; Heavy 4+. Complexity concerns dependencies, not power. There is no default initiative roll.

Each actor has one coherent Main Intent and one ordinary independent Reaction Slot per round, refreshed at Council. Default reactions need an actual trigger, immediate Complexity 0–1 and self/touch or single-target scope. Whole-round movement is shared across tracks and reactions.

For colliding timing, Clash rolls determine order; higher goes first. On ties resolve simultaneously or use the stronger fictional position. For directly opposing effort, Contest determines the immediate winner. Do not demand attack, save, clash and contest automatically for every use. New circumstances may require revising a remaining intent.

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Rulings and creature foundations

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A useful ruling / authored example

Mira wants to divert water so a worker can cross. Her Verb II, Water I and Near permissions cover redirecting existing located water within 30 ft. She sees the worker at 20 ft. The table agrees Magical DC 12 and a restriction: she must keep directing this channel until the crossing is complete.

Her Magical-trained +6 plus roll 7 gives 13. The diversion works. Record the restriction and its ending; no automatic damage occurs. Holding a wider flood under pressure could change the appraisal. Reviving someone drowned would introduce different behavior, not merely a greater number of water dice.

Keep the alpha boundary visible. Ordinary continuation works. Additional damage-triggered Vitality-upkeep repayment/reset remains undecided; do not impose it as a settled rule.

Calculate the creature foundation

Choose a **positive base creature budget B**. Calculate rank **r = sqrt(B / 25)** without rounding it first. "ceil" means round a fraction upward to the next whole point; a whole number stays unchanged.

Baseline	Calculation
Attribute points	ceil(3 x r)
Proficiency bonus	1 + ceil(r)
Maximum Vitality	max(1, ceil(B / 2))

Allocate exactly those nonnegative base points among Physical, Mental and Magical. Creature bases do not use the player's total 10 or base +5 cap. Choose the proficient attribute; it trains that attribute's practices and save. Apply actual modifiers separately; use the full current parent attribute for checks.

CONTINUED / CALCULATE THE CREATURE FOUNDATION

Base BU	Points	PB	Vitality
1	1	2	1
25	3	2	13
50	5	3	25
75	6	3	38
100	6	3	50
150	8	4	75
225	9	4	113
250	10	5	125
1,000	19	8	500

At B 50, r is about 1.414: ceil(3r) is 5, PB is 3 and Vitality is 25. Rounding rank first would give the wrong foundation.

Finish the actual actor

Describe motives, behavior, size, senses and movement. Acquire readable ingredients supporting its abilities; organize useful effects/capabilities. Specify targets, delivery, source/domain, output, triggers, duration and endings. Only explicit grants change action economy or defenses.

Resolve practices, saves and DC using **Create**. Use the creature Vitality baseline above, then actual modifiers or an explicitly agreed baseline override. Track base BU, spent creature BU, eligible credit and unspent build allowance separately. Equipment has its own Item BU, Load and slots.

Unspent BU grants no hidden ability. Ordinary role titles, portraits and size grant no extra reactions, damage dice, armor or healing. Test a favorable scene, a counter-approach and a lost dependency.

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A creature and its encounter

Preparing and adjudicating / Use the shared rules in Play and Create.

Canal Watcher / complete example

Purpose: a small river spirit protects a spawning bed beside a damaged sluice. It wants safe flow, warns intruders and accepts negotiation that protects the bed.

Foundation: B 25; r 1; 3 base points; Physical 2, Mental 0, Magical 1. Magical proficient; PB 2. Maximum/current Vitality 13/13; selected Magical DC = 5 + 2 + 1 = **8**.

Combined checks: Physical practices +2; Mental practices +0; Magical practices +3. Saves: Physical +2, Mental +0, Magical +3. Use those bonuses once.

Body: Small; walking 25 ft; ordinary swim/climb 13 ft; ordinary sight/hearing. No through-wall sense or special swimming grant. Capacity 20 + 5 x 2 = 30 Load; six equipped slots; no items, Item BU 0. Short-rest allowance 7 if agreed rests apply.

Acquired rule	BU
Verb II: change existing eligible states; redirect, reshape, transfer or stabilize.	8
Water I: grounded water is the bound subject, not every physical domain.	4
Near: eligible reach up to 30 ft, with actual location and delivery.	4
d8: eligible output die type; no extra behavior or automatic recipients.	4
Spent / remaining of base 25	20 / 5

Turn the Current: reference Verb II, Water I and Near to redirect or reshape existing located water within 30 ft. Appraise route, volume, recipients and opposition. Moving a resisting creature can need a contest or another agreed resolution.

Water Impact, normal authored expression: drive existing water into one located target within 30 ft, projected through an actual route. Roll **d20 + 3** against target DC; on a hit deal **1d8 Magical Water** damage. Apply cover and defenses from **Play**. No additional save, healing or extra intent is granted.

Tell and counterplay: it points at the spawning bed before attacking. It talks or retreats when the threat ends. A dry bank removes useful existing water; it cannot create water from its unspent five BU.

Repeated Watchers may share this definition, but each needs independent position, Vitality, reaction and ongoing-state records. A quantity field creates no shared damage pool.

Prepare an encounter

Record the situation/objective, Party BU, separate Party Item BU, known party size, creature definitions, quantities and relevant terrain/information. Manual totals suffice; linked sheets are optional. Unknown is different from zero.

For each entry multiply **quantity x chosen base creature BU**. Sum those subtotals for enemy creature BU. Separately sum **quantity x resolved Item BU**. Combined enemy = creature BU + Item BU. Combined party = Party BU + Party Item BU.

Difference: enemy combined minus party combined. **Ratio:** enemy combined divided by a known positive party combined. Omit a ratio if that denominator is zero or unknown. Compare actor counts when party size is known. Largest-creature share is one individual's base BU divided by total enemy creature BU, not the whole repeated row.

Creature appraisal uses chosen base BU, not merely spent acquisitions. Mirror credit is not added to base BU as another creature budget. Count equipment in Item BU once.

> **Worked appraisal.** Two 25-BU Watchers give 50 enemy BU and zero Item BU. Two level-1 characters give 50 Party BU; with 8 Party Item BU their combined total is 58. Difference is **-8**; ratio **50/58**, about **0.862**. Counts match; each Watcher holds 50% of enemy creature BU. These facts are not a difficulty grade.

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Advancement and build boundaries

Preparing and adjudicating / Use the shared rules in Play and Create.

Judge the scene as well

Review control, burst, area output, support, terrain, concealment, target location, goals, escape routes and concentration of budget. Comparable BU does not guarantee comparable danger. Provide observable tells, alternatives and opportunities to learn.

During play track phase, intent/dependencies, position/movement spent, reactions, current/maximum Vitality, consequences, maintained work and objective changes. Council does not reset wounds. Stopping an encounter preserves its aftermath; returning to the same wounded creature continues its actual state.

Reward and advance by agreement

Agree pacing and rewards with the table; no compulsory XP or per-session BU award exists. Separate fictional treasure and ordinary item value from character advancement and Item BU.

Unspent acquisition BU may buy or invent ingredients during play with agreement. Spending does not undo established level. Review new behavior and ongoing drawbacks; rising maximum Vitality alone does not heal current Vitality.

Cumulative character progression

Use these **total thresholds**, not additional payments. Bracket spikes are already included. PB = 2 + floor((level - 1) / 4). "Floor" takes the lower whole number. Maximum Vitality = (10 + current PB) x level, then actual maximum-Vitality rules.

CONTINUED / CUMULATIVE CHARACTER PROGRESSION

Level	Total BU	Level	Total BU
1	25	12	147
2	35	13	169
3	45	14	179
4	55	15	189
5	69	16	199
6	79	17	225
7	89	18	235
8	99	19	245
9	117	20	255
10	127	21	286
11	137	22	296

Beyond 21: add 10 each level, plus the next four-level bracket spikes: an extra 24 at level 25, 28 at 29, 32 at 33, continuing by +4 per bracket. Keep the explicit level-21 threshold of 286. Total at 24 is 316; at 25 it is 350; at 29 it is 418. Do not add a spike again to a cumulative value.

Advancement example: reaching total 69 establishes level 5. Baseline PB becomes 3; baseline maximum Vitality becomes (10 + 3) x 5 = 65. Apply actual active modifications. This increase alone supplies no healing.

Review a drawback honestly

Default debt ceiling = **4 x ceil(level / 4)**: 4 at levels 1-4, 8 at 5-8, 12 at 9-12, continuing. A ceiling grants no credit by itself.

Only accepted eligible drawbacks supply credit. Count acquisitions once; separate ordinary unspent BU, actual used debt and uncovered excess. Exceeding ordinary budget needs explicit DM agreement and respects permitted credit and the next-level creation ceiling. The drawback remains real; repeated references or an opposite used elsewhere create no credit/refund. **Create** gives worked ledgers.

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